

JOURNAL OF AFRICAN ARTS &

SOUND ENGINEERING AS CREATIVE PRACTICE IN GHANAIAN CHORAL MUSIC: A BIOGRAPHICAL-PHENOMENOLOGICAL STUDY OF DOMINIC OPARE ANSA-ASARE (MIDO)

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CITATION: Ayesu, S.N., Sackey, G., Quainoo, M. & Okoye, N.U. (2026). Sound engineering as creative practice in Ghanaian choral music: A biographical-phenomenological study of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare (MIDO), *Journal of African Arts and Culture*, 9(2), 325-345.

Abstract

Sound engineers are important in how choral music is captured, shaped, and presented, yet their work has received little attention in Ghanaian music scholarship. This study addresses this gap through a qualitative biographical-phenomenological study of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare, known professionally as MIDO, a sound engineer who has worked in Ghanaian choral music for more than two decades. Guided by Narrative Identity Theory, Communities of Practice Theory, and Sound Studies/Sonic Mediation Theory, the study examines how his professional identity, technical approach, and contribution to choral sound engineering developed through early musical experiences, church practice, entrepreneurship, and learning with others. Data were generated through in-depth semi-structured interviews conducted via Zoom and at MIDO Productions in Accra and analysed using reflexive thematic analysis. The findings show that his work goes beyond operating sound equipment to include creative decisions, mentorship, and the shaping of Ghanaian choral sound. The study therefore presents sound engineering in African choral music as a technical, artistic, and social practice. By focusing on a practitioner who normally works behind the scenes, the article adds another perspective to Ghanaian music scholarship and African sound studies.

Keywords: *sound engineering, biographical research, choral music, Ghanaian music, communities of practice, narrative identity, African music production, studio culture*

1. Introduction

Sound engineers have an important but often unacknowledged influence on how choral music is heard and experienced. In live performance, decisions about microphone placement, signal routing, and sound reinforcement affect what the audience hears. In recording, these decisions also influence the sound that is preserved for broadcast, archiving, and digital circulation. Despite this role, sound engineers remain underrepresented in Ghanaian music scholarship, which has largely focused on composers, performers, conductors, and the analysis of musical works.

This gap is important because choral music has occupied a central place in Ghana's religious, educational, and cultural life for more than a century (Agordoh, 2011; Dor, 1992, 2005). As choral performance has moved into professional concerts, studio recording, broadcasting, and digital media, sound engineers have become important to how the music is produced and presented. However, their limited presence in Ghanaian music scholarship means that little is known about the technical decisions that shape and preserve contemporary Ghanaian choral sound.

Within international music production scholarship, this imbalance has begun to be corrected. Researchers including Meintjes (2003), Porcello (2004), Pinch and Bijsterveld (2004, 2011), Beer (2014), Thompson and McIntyre (2020), and Horning (2013) have collectively reframed sound engineers as creative and interpretive practitioners whose technical decisions actively shape musical meaning, listener experience, and the sonic identity of recorded culture. Within Ghanaian scholarship, Owusu-Poku (2021) made a landmark contribution by foregrounding the work of recording engineer Francis Kwakye at the Ghana Film Studio during the 1970s, demonstrating how engineers adapted studio practice to local musical aesthetics. More recently, Adu-Gilmore (2016) and Sowah (2025) have further signalled growing scholarly engagement with sound production in Ghanaian contexts. Nevertheless, biographical documentation of influential contemporary sound engineers, particularly within choral music, remains a critical gap in the literature.

This study responds directly to that gap. It investigates the life, professional formation, technical philosophy, and contributions of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare, known within Ghana's choral music community as MIDO, an influential sound engineer who has shaped the sonic presentation of Ghanaian choral music for more than two decades. Through MIDO Productions, established in 2001, Ansa-Asare has worked with leading Ghanaian choral ensembles including Harmonious Chorale Ghana, One Voice Choir, Celestial Evangel Choir, and Gramophone Chorus, while also contributing to major choral and orchestral productions within and beyond Ghana. Despite these sustained contributions, he remains undocumented within academic literature.

The study examines how Ansa-Asare's early musical socialisation and educational experiences shaped his professional formation as a sound engineer, the technical philosophy and engineering approaches that characterise his practice within Ghanaian choral music production, and the ways his work has contributed to professional culture, mentorship, and the sonic presentation of Ghanaian choral music. A qualitative biographical-phenomenological approach, informed by Narrative Identity Theory, Communities of Practice Theory, and Sound Studies/Sonic Mediation Theory, was used to address these concerns.

2. Theoretical Framework

This study uses three theoretical frameworks to examine Ansa-Asare's personal history, professional development, technical practice, and contribution to Ghanaian choral music. The three frameworks were selected because each helps to explain a different aspect of his experience: how he understands his professional life, how he learned through participation with others, and how his technical decisions shape sound. They also informed the interview guide, thematic analysis, and organisation of the findings.

The first framework is Narrative Identity Theory, which explains how people develop an understanding of themselves through the stories they tell about their experiences. McAdams and McLean (2013) describe narrative identity as an evolving life story through which people connect past experiences, present circumstances, and future expectations. This framework is relevant to the study because it helps to explain how Ansa-Asare's childhood musical experiences, church involvement, entrepreneurial challenges, mentorship activities, and long engagement with choral music contributed to the development of his professional identity. Rae (2002) and Cohen and Musson (2000) similarly show that professional identity can develop through social practice, relationships, and reflection on experience, rather than through formal training alone.

The second framework is *Communities of Practice Theory*, originally formulated by Lave and Wenger (1991) and subsequently elaborated by Wenger (1998). The theory argues that learning and professional competence develop through sustained, active participation in communities organised around shared practices, tools, and purposes. Knowledge is therefore acquired socially, through collaboration, observation, mentorship, and practical engagement, rather than through formal instruction in isolation. This framework illuminates how Ansa-Asare's expertise emerged through decades of participation in church music communities, choir rehearsal environments, studio production networks, and live sound reinforcement contexts. It also provides an analytical lens for examining the mentorship culture at MIDO Productions, where younger practitioners acquire technical and professional knowledge through legitimate peripheral participation in real production activities (Wenger, 1998).

The third framework is Sound Studies and Sonic Mediation Theory. It explains how sound, listening, and technology influence the way music is produced and experienced. Scholars in this area argue that recording technology does not simply capture sound. The choices made by engineers in particular acoustic, cultural, and institutional settings also shape the final sound (Bull, 2018; Pinch & Bijsterveld, 2004, 2011). This is relevant to Ansa-Asare's work because his decisions about microphone selection and placement, mixing, mastering, and live reinforcement influence how Ghanaian choral music is heard. The framework therefore helps the study to examine the sound engineer as both a technical and creative practitioner.

3. Review of Related Literature

3.1 Ghanaian Music Scholarship and the Documentation of Musical Practitioners

Ghanaian music scholarship has generated a substantial body of work on composition, performance, and stylistic analysis. Studies by Dor (1992, 2005) and Amuah (2012, 2013, 2014) have examined the integration of indigenous musical materials into Ghanaian art and choral music, attending to compositional techniques, harmonic language, and tonal organisation. Biographical and genre-oriented studies have similarly focused on visible performers and composers: Coffie (2019) analysed Ebo Taylor's engagement with highlife and jazz, Shipley (2013) examined hiplife artists and questions of identity and globalisation, and Kaye (1999) documented Koo Nimo's musical life and cultural background. Twum-Barimah (2023) extended this tradition through analysis of compositional techniques in selected works of J. P. Johnson. Collectively, these studies reflect a sustained commitment to documenting Ghanaian musical personalities and traditions, while also revealing a significant structural gap: the near-total absence of technical practitioners from the scholarly record.

Sound engineers, recording producers, and live sound specialists appear in existing Ghanaian scholarship only peripherally, referenced within broader discussions of studio sessions or concert production rather than examined as subjects of scholarly inquiry in their own right. This absence carries analytical consequences. As Horning (2013) demonstrated through her history of studio recording culture in the United States, recording studios are not passive sites of documentation but active environments in which technical decisions about microphone placement, signal processing, and spatial imaging shape the sonic identity of musical culture. If the studio is a site of cultural production, then those who make technical decisions within it are cultural producers, and their exclusion from the scholarly record constitutes a systematic distortion of how musical culture is understood.

Owusu-Poku's (2021) study of Francis Kwakye and the Ghana Film Studio during the 1970s provides an important exception to this pattern within Ghanaian scholarship. By centring a recording engineer as the primary subject of investigation, Owusu-Poku demonstrated that studio practitioners actively shaped the development of Ghanaian highlife sound through technological adaptation and aesthetic decision-making, a finding that substantively reframes the history of Ghanaian recorded music. Adu-Gilmore (2016) similarly drew attention to the creative processes of Ghanaian music producers, while Mark et al. (2022) examined the underrecognition of behind-the-scenes contributors within Ghanaian popular music contexts. Despite these contributions, biographical documentation of sound engineers within Ghanaian choral music, a domain with its own distinct technical and aesthetic requirements, remains an unaddressed gap.

3.2 Sound Engineering as Creative and Interpretive Practice

International sound studies have increasingly described sound engineering as both a technical and creative practice. In her study of a South African recording studio, Meintjes (2003) showed that recording personnel influence musical identity and sound through the technical decisions they make. Porcello (2004) also examined the professional language and judgement used by sound engineers and showed that technical decisions can also involve aesthetic choices. Pinch and Bijsterveld (2004) similarly argued that sound engineers can be as important as musicians in producing the final sound. These studies show that recording technology does not simply reproduce a performance; the engineer's decisions also influence what is heard.

Beer (2014) examined how recording engineers balance artistic judgement with technical responsibility while working with performers and producers. Thompson and McIntyre (2020) also describe sound engineering as a creative practice that involves decisions about sonic texture, spatial imaging, and musical clarity. Pras and Guastavino (2011) further show that the decisions made by producers and engineers can influence the final sound of a recording. These studies support the view adopted in this study that sound engineering involves both technical and artistic judgement.

Within African contexts specifically, sound engineering and studio culture have received growing scholarly attention. Coplan's (2003) examination of South African music production highlighted the role of technological mediation in shaping musical identity across colonial and postcolonial contexts. More recently, Sowah (2025) examined stylistic hybridity in Ghanaian choral highlife, a genre in which recording and live sound production decisions are central to the music's aesthetic character. This emerging body of African sound studies scholarship supports the theoretical position of this study: that understanding contemporary African musical culture requires sustained attention to the technical practitioners who shape how that music sounds.

Another important issue in sound engineering is the relationship between musicianship and technical competence. Hugonnet and Walder (1997) emphasise the importance of musical understanding, including knowledge of acoustic space, stereo imaging, and tonal balance, in professional recording. Ovsianikov (2021) also argues that recording strategies depend on artistic intention and the acoustic environment and therefore require careful listening as well as knowledge of equipment. These ideas are relevant to Ansa-Asare because his work as an organist, choir director, and accompanist has continued to inform his engineering practice.

The literature reviewed above points to three issues that are important to this study. First, sound engineers make technical and creative decisions that influence the final sound of music. Second, documenting the work of technical practitioners is important to music scholarship. Third, there is still limited documentation of sound engineers in Ghanaian and African music scholarship. This study addresses this gap through the biographical study of Ansa-Asare.

4. Methodology

4.1 Research Design

This study employed a qualitative biographical-phenomenological research design to examine the life, professional formation, technical philosophy, and contributions of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare within Ghana's choral music production industry. Biographical research focuses on understanding and interpreting how individuals construct meaning from lived experience, how personal history shapes identity and professional development, and how individual trajectories illuminate broader social and cultural processes (Creswell & Poth, 2018; Roberts, 2002). Phenomenology, as developed by Moustakas (1994) and extended by Van Manen (2016), attends to the structure and meaning of lived experience as consciously perceived: what an experience is like for the person living it, rather than merely what occurred in an observable sequence. The combination of these approaches was appropriate because the study sought not only to construct a career narrative but also to understand the meanings, values, and interpretive dispositions that characterise Ansa-Asare's professional practice as a sound engineer.

The study is positioned within the interpretivist qualitative research paradigm, which holds that social reality is constructed through human experience, interaction, and meaning-making, rather than existing independently of the individuals who inhabit it (Schwandt, 2014). Interpretivism guided the study's commitment to understanding Ansa-Asare's subjective experiences and professional philosophy from within his own interpretive framework, rather than imposing an external evaluative standard onto his practice.

The case of Ansa-Asare constitutes what Stake (1995) terms an intrinsic case study: one selected not because it represents a statistically typical instance of a phenomenon, but because the individual's specific experiences, contributions, and positioning offer a particularly rich and illuminating window into an underexplored domain. Analytical generalisation (Yin, 2018), the drawing of theoretical insights that extend beyond the specific case, rather than statistical generalisation, is therefore the appropriate epistemological standard for this study's knowledge claims. The findings contribute to theoretical understanding of how sound engineering expertise develops, how professional identity is formed in contexts of informal learning, and how technical practitioners shape musical culture in African production environments.

4.2 Participant Selection

Purposive sampling was employed to select the participant based on his demonstrable expertise, professional standing, and centrality to the phenomenon under investigation (Creswell & Poth, 2018; Patton, 2015). Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare (MIDO) was selected because he has worked as a professional sound engineer in Ghana's choral music industry for more than two decades, he has collaborated with multiple leading Ghanaian choral ensembles, he is the founder of MIDO Productions (a studio with a significant track record in choral and commercial music production), and he has been involved in mentorship and technological innovation within Ghana's live performance culture. These criteria positioned him as an information-rich case (Patton, 2015) capable of generating substantive data relevant to all three research questions.

4.3 Data Collection

Data were collected primarily through semi-structured in-depth interviews. Prior to the interviews, a formal introductory letter from the Department of Music Education, University of Education, Winneba, was presented to the participant, explaining the academic purpose of the study and outlining data use procedures. The interview guide was shared in advance to allow the participant adequate preparation and reflection on the themes under discussion.

The first interview was conducted via Zoom on 23 January 2026 and lasted approximately two hours and fifteen minutes. The semi-structured format allowed for flexibility in following emerging themes, probing significant experiences, and enabling the participant to organise his narrative in ways that reflected his own interpretive priorities. A follow-up interview was conducted on 12 February 2026 at MIDO Productions in Accra, lasting approximately one hour and forty minutes. This second session provided opportunities to revisit, clarify, and deepen themes identified in the first interview, and to explore dimensions of the participant's experience that had not been fully elaborated in the initial session. The visit also permitted informal observation of the studio environment and operational context, providing supplementary contextual data used to corroborate and enrich interview-derived accounts.

Interview themes encompassed early life and family background; education and musical training; career development and the founding of MIDO Productions; entry into choral sound engineering; professional philosophy and technical approach; challenges in the industry; and mentorship and professional vision. Both interviews were audio-recorded with the informed consent of the participant and subsequently transcribed verbatim.

4.4 Data Analysis

Data were analysed using reflexive thematic analysis, following the six-phase protocol established by Braun and Clarke (2006, 2022): (1) familiarisation with the data through repeated reading and annotation of transcripts; (2) systematic generation of initial codes across the entire data set; (3) construction of candidate themes by collating codes into meaningful clusters; (4) review of themes against the coded data and the full data set to assess coherence and coverage; (5) definition and naming of themes in relation to the research questions and theoretical frameworks; and (6) production of the analytical account. The theoretical frameworks, Narrative Identity Theory, Communities of Practice Theory, and Sound Studies/Sonic Mediation Theory, served as sensitising concepts throughout the analytical process, guiding attention toward particular dimensions of the data without predetermining the thematic structure that emerged from it.

4.5 Trustworthiness

Trustworthiness was addressed through procedures aligned with Lincoln and Guba's (1985) criteria. Credibility was strengthened through two interview sessions conducted over three weeks, follow-up questions used to clarify and deepen initial accounts, and systematic comparison of interpretations across both interview transcripts. Dependability was supported by maintaining a methodological audit trail that included interview guides, coding logs, and reflective analytical memos. Transferability was supported through detailed description of the participant and professional context so that readers can judge the relevance of the findings to other settings. Confirmability was supported through reflexive attention to the researchers' assumptions during analysis. The study relied on the participant's interview accounts as its primary source of evidence because the purpose was to understand his professional experiences, technical reasoning, and interpretation of his own practice.

5. Findings

5.1 Early Musical Socialisation and Family Background

Ansa-Asare's professional formation as a sound engineer did not begin in a studio or with a piece of equipment. It began in a domestic environment saturated with organised musical sound. His father was a trained music teacher who taught at Asanteman Senior High School and Prempeh College in Kumasi before eventually serving as a District Director of Education. This professional background meant that the family home functioned as a continuous site of musical engagement: listening, discussion, and structured exposure to sound were embedded in everyday life rather than confined to formal occasions.

Central to this early formation was the family's radiogram and its collection of classical orchestral recordings, works by Beethoven, Bach, and Tchaikovsky, which the father used for teaching purposes. For a young Ansa-Asare, these were not background sounds but formative

sonic events. He recalled their impact during the interview conducted on 23 January 2026: “When he starts playing those records, it will wake me up and I’ll come in and sit in the hall.”

Although he was too young to engage with the recordings analytically, repeated immersive exposure to orchestral music during early childhood cultivated sensitivity to tonal balance, dynamic contrast, and sonic texture, perceptual capacities that later became the foundation of his engineering practice. This finding aligns with Porcello’s (2004) argument that sound engineering expertise develops through prolonged listening culture as much as through formal technical training, and with Thompson and McIntyre’s (2019) observation that interpretive experience, the capacity to hear sound as structured meaning, precedes and informs technical skill acquisition.

The domestic musical environment extended beyond listening to active performance. As the fifth of eight children, Ansa-Asare was regularly called upon to perform for family visitors from as young as six years of age, with performances attracting praise and modest financial rewards. He described the motivational dynamic that this created: “I want to always make sure that I have a new piece so that when visitors come, I can entertain them” (Interview, 23 January 2026).

This early cultivation of discipline, performance readiness, and intrinsic motivation through social recognition speaks directly to a central premise of Narrative Identity Theory: that formative childhood experiences are the raw material from which a purposeful professional self is later constructed (McAdams & McLean, 2013). The family’s strong Presbyterian values, emphasising discipline, punctuality, stewardship, and excellence, provided the normative framework within which these experiences were interpreted and internalised. Fung (2016) has similarly identified the role of faith-based values and familial socialisation in shaping the professional orientation of creative practitioners operating at the intersection of music and institutional life.

5.2 Education and Early Musical Training

Ansa-Asare’s formal musical training combined structured Western classical pedagogy with intensive practical involvement in church and choral performance traditions. From early childhood, he pursued graded keyboard examinations through the Associated Board of the Royal Schools of Music (ABRSM), a system that, while frequently critiqued for its Eurocentric orientation (Kok, 2023), provided rigorous technical discipline in sight-reading, music theory, and performance precision. This formal training complemented rather than displaced his simultaneous engagement with Ghanaian church music traditions.

By the age of nine, Ansa-Asare was serving as organist at Kwadaso Presbyterian Church in Kumasi. His involvement in church music deepened throughout secondary school at Prempeh College, where he served as school organist and pianist from Form One through Form Six and performed regularly for several Kumasi churches, including the Lutheran Church, Bantama Presbyterian Church, and Ramseyer Presbyterian Church. These experiences, encompassing choir accompaniment, congregational singing, acoustic navigation of different church spaces, and weekly engagement with choral repertoire, constituted an extended practical apprenticeship that proved foundational to his later engineering work. Spears and Dordzro (2024) similarly identified church participation and performance-based apprenticeship as critical pathways in the musical formation of Ghanaian practitioners.

Significantly, Ansa-Asare pursued an undergraduate degree in Agriculture (with specialisation in Economics) at the University of Ghana, Legon, rather than in music. His choice reflected both the limited status of music as a degree discipline in Ghana at the time and his family's broader educational expectations. He subsequently acknowledged, however, that his training in economics proved directly valuable during the later establishment of MIDO Productions, where financial planning and business sustainability required analytical skills not typically cultivated within music conservatoire training. His educational trajectory therefore reflects a pattern that Rae (2002) identified as characteristic of creative entrepreneurs: the intersection of artistic, academic, and entrepreneurial learning within a single professional formation.

Although his undergraduate studies were outside music, Ansa-Asare remained committed to advancing his professional competence in music and media production throughout his career. As part of this commitment to lifelong learning, he undertook specialised professional studies at Berklee College of Music's Online Extension School in Boston, Massachusetts. In 2012, he earned the Specialist Certificate in Live Sound Production and subsequently completed additional professional certificates in Cinematography and Vocal Techniques. These internationally recognised qualifications complemented the experiential knowledge he had acquired through years of church musicianship, live performance, and studio practice, broadening his expertise in audio production, visual media, and vocal performance. Rather than marking the beginning of his engineering career, these certifications represented an important stage in his continuing professional development, and reflected his commitment to maintaining international standards while remaining deeply rooted in Ghanaian musical practice.

Throughout his university years, Ansa-Asare continued experimenting with recording technology. He converted the wardrobe in his dormitory room at Legon Hall Annex into a makeshift recording booth by filling it with clothing to reduce sound reflections. He also borrowed a four-track recorder from George Abban, an engineer at Ark Studios in Tema, which he used to record choir music with his peers in this improvised space. During university vacations, he rented recording equipment to record youth choirs at home. Reflecting on this period, he stated: "We were recording choir music in the room with a borrowed four-track machine and using clothes in the wardrobe to control the sound" (Interview, 23 January 2026).

These informal experiments, conducted without formal instruction, professional supervision, or adequate equipment, constituted a form of self-directed learning through legitimate peripheral participation (Lave & Wenger, 1991): the practitioner positioned at the margins of a professional community, acquiring knowledge through real engagement with real tasks. Long before he entered professional production environments, Ansa-Asare had developed critical listening habits, technical curiosity, and practical problem-solving capacities through sustained experimentation with recording processes.

5.3 Transition into Professional Music Production

Following graduation from the University of Ghana, Legon, Ansa-Asare did not immediately enter music production. He managed a poultry farm owned by Dr. Asamoah, a period he described as materially comfortable, involving access to a vehicle, stable accommodation, and regular income. Music remained a personally significant practice during this time, but had not yet become the centre of his professional ambitions.

A pivotal encounter catalysed the transition. During a trip to Accra, Ansa-Asare met an old college acquaintance, identified as Freddy, who had recently returned from the United Kingdom and was working in music production. The encounter prompted a direct and challenging question: why was someone with Ansa-Asare's musical background not working in music? This relational moment of reflection, combined with encouragement from his mother and wife, initiated a process of career reconstitution that Rae (2002) and Cohen and Musson (2000) describe as central to entrepreneurial identity formation: the recognition of a gap between one's current position and a more authentic professional self, and the social relationships that make reorientation both thinkable and actionable.

The early years in Accra tested that commitment severely. Ansa-Asare worked briefly at a media distribution company before joining a shipping firm in a marketing role, continuing to build what would become MIDO Productions in parallel using a single room in his mother's house in Nima. The room was divided into a control area, a live recording space, and a reception area. Because he was still employed, a young man from his church congregation supervised the studio during working hours, while Ansa-Asare recorded and mixed projects during evenings and weekends. This improvised infrastructure, a family home space repurposed as a commercial studio, reflects the resourcefulness that characterises the formation of independent creative enterprises in contexts where formal industry support is limited (Ansong & Boateng, 2019).

The studio's first significant commercial breakthrough came through the production of two jingles: one for a telecommunications company (the mobile network then known as One Touch, later Vodafone Ghana) and another for Goldfields Ghana. He reflected on the financial significance of these commissions: "Those two jingles gave me almost eight to ten months of my salary at the time" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

Encouraged by this success, Ansa-Asare resigned from salaried employment to commit fully to MIDO Productions. The months immediately following this decision proved extremely difficult. With virtually no new commissions entering the studio for close to three months, he relied on financial support from his wife and borrowed capital to fund basic business promotion. He recalled: "For almost three months after resigning, there was no work coming in" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This experience of prolonged commercial uncertainty following an initial success is characteristic of the early stages of independent creative enterprise, where delayed financial returns and irregular project flows require resilience and adaptive capacity (Ansong & Boateng, 2019; Rae, 2002). Ansa-Asare described advice from a communications consultant about brand positioning as pivotal in sustaining his resolve during this period, an illustration of how informal mentorship and professional networks function as support systems within Ghana's creative industries in the absence of formal institutional infrastructure.

The studio gradually expanded its commercial portfolio to include corporate jingles, radio drama productions, festival audio, live event reinforcement, and eventually choral recording, a diversification strategy that enabled the studio to sustain itself financially while building specialist expertise across multiple production formats. By the early 2000s, MIDO Productions had become a recognised name within Ghana's media landscape, with jingles for major organisations including Nestlé Ghana (reportedly aired on stations such as Joy FM for nearly

two decades) and Stanbic Bank establishing the studio's commercial credibility. The liberalisation of Ghana's media environment during the 1990s (Gadzekpo, 2020) had opened significant commercial opportunities for independent production outfits, and MIDO Productions emerged as one of the beneficiaries of that structural transformation.

5.4 Entry into Choral Sound Engineering

Ansa-Asare's specialisation in choral sound engineering emerged through a combination of accumulated musical competence, professional reputation, and critical opportunity. The defining encounter came through a colleague named James, who invited him to evaluate a recording produced for a prominent Ghanaian composer. Upon reviewing the recording, Ansa-Asare identified significant deficiencies in the sonic balance and production quality, what he described as "a lot of holes" in the sound. He was subsequently given the opportunity to re-engineer the audio work, and the improvement was immediately recognised by the conductor and production team. This experience initiated a chain of professional referrals within Ghanaian choral circles, what Wenger (1998) would describe as a movement from peripheral to fuller participation within an established community of practice.

What distinguished Ansa-Asare from other engineers operating in Ghana's music production environment was the depth of his pre-existing musical knowledge. By the time he entered professional choral recording, he had spent nearly three decades actively involved in church music as organist, accompanist, choir director, and conductor. He possessed detailed familiarity with choral repertoire, voice leading, harmonic structure, and the interpretive conventions of Ghanaian choral performance. He reflected on this advantage explicitly: "A lot of the songs that the choir is going to bring, yes, I have heard them. I know the arrangements, and people didn't think that was necessary in engineering" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This comment reveals a critical insight about the nature of choral sound engineering as practised by Ansa-Asare: the technical process is not separable from musical understanding. His knowledge of voice crossing, counterpoint, and harmonic movement within choral textures directly informed his microphone placement decisions, his mixing approach, and his capacity to anticipate sonic challenges before they materialised during sessions. Porcello (2004) frames this kind of practitioner as an interpretive professional rather than a technical operator, and Horning (2013) similarly characterises the recording studio as a collaborative space in which technical practitioners actively shape musical meaning through informed aesthetic decisions. Both descriptions fit Ansa-Asare's account closely.

Over time, Ansa-Asare established sustained working relationships with leading Ghanaian choral ensembles, including Harmonious Chorale Ghana, One Voice Choir, Celestial Evangel Choir, and Gramophone Chorus. A particularly significant demonstration of his work occurred during the COVID-19 pandemic period, when a live choral production he engineered for Harmonious Chorale Ghana received a nomination alongside a studio-produced work by a prominent Ghanaian recording artist within a major music awards category. He recalled that at the awards event, audience members could not readily distinguish the acoustic quality of the live choral production from that of the professionally recorded studio work, an outcome that he cited as evidence of both the artistic potential of Ghanaian choral music and the technical possibilities of skilled live sound reinforcement.

The findings show that Ansa-Asare's sound engineering practice combines technical knowledge, musical understanding, and experience gained through working with others. His

decisions about microphone placement, spatial imaging, and mixing are informed by his musical background, his experience in different production settings, and the professional identity he has developed over time. This supports studies that describe sound engineering as both a technical and creative practice (Beer, 2014; Meintjes, 2003; Porcello, 2004; Thompson & McIntyre, 2020).

5.5 Professional Philosophy and Technical Approach

Ansa-Asare's professional philosophy reflects the convergence of extensive practical experience, musicianship, and a sustained commitment to continuous learning. While decades of church musicianship, studio practice, and live sound reinforcement laid the foundation of his engineering approach, he continued to refine his professional competencies through specialised training, including advanced certification programmes at Berklee College of Music's Online Extension School. Rather than replacing experiential knowledge, these programmes complemented his existing expertise and reinforced his multidisciplinary understanding of sound production, vocal performance, and audiovisual communication.

At the centre of Ansa-Asare's engineering philosophy is a commitment to transparency: the belief that the sound engineer's primary responsibility is to reveal the artistic intentions of performers, conductors, and composers rather than to impose a personal aesthetic upon them. This philosophy is expressed in the operational slogan of MIDO Productions, "Your talent comes to life, not mine," and was articulated through a striking analogy during the interview: "When the picture is not nice, the photographer is not good. But when it is nice, it's still your image, the way you did your mouth or your face is what the lens captured" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

The findings also show that MIDO Productions has served as more than a commercial recording studio. It has provided a place where younger practitioners learn technical skills, professional values, and studio practices through direct involvement in production work (Lave & Wenger, 1991; Wenger, 1998). This is important for Ghana's creative industries because much sound engineering knowledge is still learned informally through studios and mentorship. Supporting such learning environments can therefore contribute to the development of professional competence in the industry. This finding agrees with Ngongalah et al. (2021) and Peretomode and Ikoya (2019), who identify mentorship as important to professional development in African contexts.

Ansa-Asare's technical approach to microphone selection challenged a widespread assumption within Ghanaian choral production circles: that condenser microphones are inherently superior to dynamic microphones. He argued that no microphone type is universally appropriate because its effectiveness depends on the acoustic environment, ensemble configuration, and production objectives. He placed particular emphasis on transient response, the microphone's capacity to capture the initial attack and character of a sound before it settles into sustained resonance, arguing that listeners perceive these subtle differences even when they lack the technical vocabulary to describe them: "They will use lay terms and say, 'I say ah, I say aha', but they wouldn't know what is causing the difference" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This observation reflects an understanding of perceptual psychoacoustics consistent with the broader sound studies argument that listening is an interpretive act shaped by experience, expectation, and cultural context (Pinch & Bijsterveld, 2004). His microphone philosophy also

informed his approach to placement. He carefully distinguished between stereo microphone configurations for studio recording and mono reinforcement techniques for live performance, often preferring to employ only two strategically positioned microphones and allowing the natural acoustics of the performance space to contribute to the overall sonic image whenever conditions permitted. These principles correspond closely with the stereophonic recording practices discussed by Hugonnet and Walder (1997) and with Ovsianikov's (2021) argument that recording strategies should be adapted to specific acoustic environments and artistic intentions.

When choral balance was inconsistent and room acoustics insufficient, Ansa-Asare employed close spot microphones while simultaneously addressing a challenge he identified as common within Ghanaian choral performance: choir directors positioning singers too far from microphones during live events. He explained: "Microphone does not know human voice different from any other sound" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This simple statement captures a foundational principle of live sound reinforcement: microphones capture acoustic events rather than musical intentions, making the physical relationship between performers and microphones a critical engineering variable. His practice of educating conductors and choir directors about these acoustic principles demonstrates the consultative dimension of his work, and illustrates how sound engineering in Ghanaian choral contexts extends beyond technical operation to include professional communication, collaboration, and education.

Ansa-Asare's mixing philosophy was equally grounded in musical understanding. Drawing directly from his experience as a choir director and accompanist, he conceptualised each vocal section as fulfilling a distinct harmonic and textural function: basses establishing harmonic direction, sopranos carrying melodic material, and tenors and altos contributing tonal colour within the choral texture. Consequently, his mixing decisions responded continuously to melodic movement, harmonic progression, and moments of voice crossing, relying on score awareness and interpretive listening rather than predetermined presets.

A particularly distinctive feature of his live engineering practice was his refusal to remain stationary behind the mixing console during performances. Instead, he preferred to observe the conductor directly, interpreting body language, gestures, and expressive movements in order to align his technical decisions with the conductor's musical intentions: "I never want to be behind the console. I want to watch the demeanour of the conductor, how he's interpreting it, and that's how I also move" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This practice reframes live mixing as participatory musical performance rather than purely technical supervision. It reinforces Beer's (2014) and Meintjes's (2003) shared argument that sound engineering involves continuous interaction between technical control and artistic responsiveness, and extends that argument to the Ghanaian choral context, where the conductor's interpretive authority serves as the principal musical reference point.

Ansa-Asare maintained a conservative philosophy towards mastering, arguing that mastering should function as the final refinement of an already well-balanced production rather than as a corrective process for unresolved mixing problems. He therefore resisted excessive post-production manipulation: "I don't want to spend hours and days to mix a song and use mastering to change it" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

His perspectives on analogue and digital technologies were similarly measured. He rejected the assumption that newer digital equipment automatically produces superior sound, maintaining instead that sound quality is fundamentally determined by the engineer's listening ability, musicianship, and critical judgement rather than by equipment cost or technological novelty. He cited his continued use of a Roland XV-88 keyboard, purchased in 2004, as evidence that enduring principles of musical listening and sound perception remain more significant than successive waves of technological innovation.

5.6 Challenges in the Industry

Ansa-Asare's professional journey involved sustained encounters with financial, social, and relational challenges that he described with a candour and equanimity that themselves reflect a mature professional identity. The most acute financial pressures occurred during the early years of MIDO Productions following his resignation from salaried employment, when the studio operated for close to three months without commercial income. He was financially supported during this period by his wife and relied on borrowed capital to sustain basic promotional activities.

Beyond financial instability, Ansa-Asare identified the social undervaluation of music as a profession in Ghana as a persistent structural challenge. He argued that musicians and technical practitioners were frequently accorded less professional respect than those in more conventionally prestigious occupations, despite music's demonstrated capacity to shape emotional states and influence human behaviour: "To be able to psychologically influence somebody and change his mood and his thinking and his focus, you can tell me that that person doesn't understand" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This observation connects directly to Beer's (2014) analysis of the ambivalent professional status of recording engineers, who occupy a complex position in which creative contribution is real but often invisible, and whose authority over sonic outcomes is exercised behind the scenes of visible cultural performance. Similar patterns of underrecognition for behind-the-scenes contributors have been documented within Ghanaian popular music contexts by Mark et al. (2022) and, in the domain of recording history, by Owusu-Poku (2021).

A recurring relational challenge concerned the management of client relationships in which professional expertise and client authority came into conflict. Ansa-Asare described an experience in which a conductor independently modified a completed mix in ways that, in his professional judgment, compromised its quality. The modified version subsequently attracted criticism from choir members who had not heard the original. This episode illustrates a point Meintjes (2003) makes about the negotiative dimension of sound production: recorded sonic outcomes emerge not from unilateral technical decisions but from relational processes involving competing forms of authority, expertise, and aesthetic preference.

In response to recurring disputes about production decisions, Ansa-Asare developed a systematic practice of providing "listening copies," provisional mixes shared with clients before final mastering, to enable collaborative review and approval prior to the finalisation of productions. This protocol reflects a sophisticated approach to managing professional accountability within creative production environments, and illustrates the communication and negotiation skills that, alongside technical competence, constitute the full scope of the sound engineer's professional repertoire.

Ansa-Asare also identified broader structural challenges within Ghana's music production industry: the absence of formal licensing systems or regulatory frameworks governing who may establish a studio and present themselves as a professional sound engineer, and the consequent variability in production quality across the industry. He further noted that inadequate recognition and institutional support for technical practitioners within Ghana's creative industries limited long-term professional sustainability for many practitioners in the field. Arkhurst and Amoh-Yaboah (2024) have similarly identified performance practice limitations, including rhythmic misinterpretation among some Ghanaian choir directors, as factors that directly affect the conditions under which recording engineers and live sound practitioners must work.

5.7 Mentorship and the Transmission of Professional Knowledge

Since the establishment of MIDO Productions in 2001, the studio has functioned simultaneously as a commercial production facility and an informal site of professional education. Over more than two decades, a succession of young practitioners, including sound engineers, music producers, video technicians, lighting operators, and other creative professionals, have passed through the studio environment, acquiring practical knowledge through direct participation in real production activities. This model of learning through participation aligns closely with Lave and Wenger's (1991) concept of legitimate peripheral participation: novice practitioners gaining access to professional knowledge not through decontextualised instruction, but through graduated involvement in authentic practice communities.

The knowledge transmitted within this mentorship environment reflects the breadth of Ansa-Asare's own professional development. Drawing upon decades of experience in church musicianship, studio production, live sound reinforcement, entrepreneurship, and continuous professional learning, including specialised training at Berklee College of Music, he has cultivated a multidisciplinary approach to mentoring that integrates technical competence, musical sensitivity, professional ethics, and creative problem-solving. His emphasis extends beyond operating equipment to developing critical listening skills, collaborative practice, and a commitment to lifelong learning among emerging practitioners.

Several of Ansa-Asare's mentees subsequently established independent careers: some worked in technical roles with major Ghanaian media organisations including GH One and TV3, while others founded independent production companies, including Think Media, a production unit that emerged directly from the studio's mentorship culture. He reflected on their progress with evident personal satisfaction: "Just like your own child. You want to see them go far in life" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

Significantly, Ansa-Asare expressed neither professional anxiety nor competitive resentment toward former mentees who established independent operations or pursued opportunities with organisations other than MIDO Productions. This perspective reflects a conception of mentorship as an investment in the long-term health of Ghana's music production industry, rather than as an instrument of personal professional advantage, an orientation consistent with Ngongalah et al.'s (2021) and Peretomode and Ikoya's (2019) arguments that mentorship in African professional contexts functions as a strategy for building collective competence and industry sustainability rather than merely transmitting individual expertise.

Beyond studio mentorship, Ansa-Asare contributed to broader technological innovation within Ghana's live performance culture. Beginning in 2008, he became involved in introducing and applying lapel microphone technology within live stage drama productions in Ghana, a collaboration that reportedly continued for approximately ten years and attracted the interest of educational institutions, including the University of Education, Winneba, which sent students to observe production processes at MIDO Productions. His involvement in technical education and knowledge transfer across institutional boundaries illustrates the role that practitioner-educators play in bridging academic training and professional practice within Ghana's creative industries.

Looking toward the future, Ansa-Asare described ambitious plans for the physical expansion of MIDO Productions, envisioning a multi-studio complex capable of accommodating several simultaneous large-scale productions while serving as a centre for professional training and creative collaboration. He simultaneously expressed a desire to reduce the travelling demands of live touring work in order to be more present in his children's lives, a reflection on the enduring interaction between professional commitment and family responsibility within his life narrative. He concluded his reflections on the profession with advice for aspiring sound engineers: "They shouldn't settle to look out for money, but they should follow their passion" (Interview, 12 February 2026).

This advice, grounded in more than two decades of professional practice, continuous learning, and mentorship, reflects a philosophy in which sustained commitment to craft, lifelong professional development, and musical integrity, rather than the pursuit of short-term commercial reward, constitute the foundation of a durable and meaningful career.

6. Discussion

The findings of this study yield several theoretically significant insights that extend beyond the individual biography of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare to illuminate broader questions about sound engineering practice, professional identity formation, and the documentation of technical practitioners within African musical culture.

Sound engineering as simultaneously technical, artistic, and socially embedded practice

The findings show that Ansa-Asare's sound engineering practice is best understood through the interaction of the three frameworks used in the study. His decisions about microphone placement, spatial imaging, and mixing are connected to his musical understanding, his participation in different professional communities, and the professional identity he has developed over time. This supports studies that describe sound engineering as both technical and creative practice (Beer, 2014; Meintjes, 2003; Porcello, 2004; Thompson & McIntyre, 2020). This study adds a Ghanaian choral music perspective to this discussion.

The role of musicianship in engineering excellence

A particularly significant finding is that Ansa-Asare's technical expertise was not separable from, but was fundamentally grounded in, his prior and ongoing practice as a musician. His capacity to anticipate voice-crossing challenges within choral arrangements, to follow conductorial interpretation through body language, and to make real-time mixing decisions based on harmonic awareness all derived from decades of active musical participation as organist, accompanist, and choir director. The findings further demonstrate that this

experiential foundation was strengthened through a sustained commitment to lifelong professional development. Rather than relying exclusively on accumulated practical experience, Ansa-Asare continually expanded his professional competencies through specialised training, including internationally recognised certification in live sound production, cinematography, and vocal techniques. These experiences illustrate that professional excellence in sound engineering emerges from the dynamic interaction between musicianship, experiential learning, and continuous professional education, with each dimension reinforcing rather than replacing the others.

This finding directly challenges production-centred models of engineering training that emphasise equipment proficiency over musical understanding. It suggests instead that sound engineering education, particularly within choral and orchestral contexts, should adopt a more holistic approach that integrates musicianship, practical industry experience, and opportunities for continuous professional development alongside technical instruction. Within the Communities of Practice framework, this integration of musicianship, lifelong learning, and technical competence represents not a coincidental biographical feature but a specific form of professional capital accumulated through sustained, boundary-crossing participation across musical, educational, and technical practice communities.

Narrative identity and the construction of a practitioner self

Analysed through the lens of Narrative Identity Theory, Ansa-Asare's professional biography reveals a coherent developmental arc through which early experiences of musical immersion, performance recognition, church service, and informal experimentation were progressively integrated into a durable professional self-understanding. This arc did not follow a linear trajectory. It included periods of apparent career discontinuity (the poultry farm, the shipping company, the three empty months after resignation) that retrospectively functioned as narrative tests, experiences through which the practitioner's commitment to his chosen identity was affirmed through sustained resilience. McAdams and McLean's (2013) insight that narrative identity is shaped through adversity as much as through achievement is strikingly illustrated by Ansa-Asare's account, in which the most difficult periods of his career are also the periods most richly articulated in his self-narrative.

The studio as a community of practice and site of cultural reproduction

MIDO Productions emerges from the findings not merely as a commercial facility but as a community of practice (Lave & Wenger, 1991; Wenger, 1998) with its own shared repertoire, mentorship culture, and professional values. The studio has functioned for over two decades as a site through which technical knowledge, engineering standards, and professional ethics are transmitted from experienced to novice practitioners through legitimate peripheral participation. This finding has implications for policy discussions about the sustainability of Ghana's creative industries. If professional knowledge in sound engineering is primarily transmitted through informal mentorship within independent production studios, then the health of those studios, and the support systems that sustain them, has direct implications for the reproduction of professional competence across the industry. Ngongalah et al. (2021) and Peretomode and Ikoya (2019) have argued that mentorship constitutes a strategic asset for African professional development; this study supports and grounds this claim within a specific, richly documented production context.

Documenting the undocumented: scholarly and heritage implications

This study's findings also carry implications for Ghanaian music scholarship as a discipline. The absence of biographical documentation for practitioners such as Ansa-Asare represents not only an individual oversight but a systematic disciplinary orientation that has rendered invisible the technical labour through which Ghanaian musical culture is sonically produced and publicly presented. The knowledge, professional philosophy, and experiential wisdom that Ansa-Asare embodies, developed over more than two decades of practice, exist at present in no archival form beyond the recordings he has engineered and the practitioners he has mentored. Biographical research of the kind conducted here is therefore not merely a retrospective scholarly exercise; it is an act of cultural preservation. This argument extends Owusu-Poku's (2021) case for the historical documentation of Ghanaian recording engineers and positions it within the broader context of African heritage scholarship.

7. Conclusion

This study has examined the life, professional formation, technical philosophy, and contributions of Dominic Opare Ansa-Asare (MIDO), an influential sound engineer whose work has significantly shaped the sonic presentation and recording culture of Ghanaian choral music over more than two decades. Through a qualitative biographical-phenomenological approach guided by Narrative Identity Theory, Communities of Practice Theory, and Sound Studies/Sonic Mediation Theory, the findings demonstrated that Ansa-Asare's expertise as a sound engineer emerged not primarily from formal technical training but from a rich and sustained process of musical socialisation, church-based practice, entrepreneurial experimentation, and communal learning. His biography illustrates, with exceptional clarity, how professional identity in sound engineering is constituted through the interaction of personal narrative, community participation, and cultural mediation, rather than through technical instruction alone.

The study's theoretical contributions are threefold. First, it provides empirical grounding within an African choral music context for the international sound studies argument that sound engineers are creative practitioners who actively constitute musical meaning rather than neutrally documenting it. Second, it demonstrates the analytical productivity of deploying multiple complementary frameworks, Narrative Identity Theory, Communities of Practice Theory, and Sound Studies, in concert, showing that each illuminates dimensions of the practitioner's experience that the others do not fully capture. Third, it extends the emerging literature on African sound engineering and studio culture by providing the first scholarly biographical account of a practitioner specialising in Ghanaian choral music production.

Methodologically, the study demonstrates the productive contribution of a single-case intrinsic biographical design to scholarship in domains where relevant practitioners are few, where their knowledge is currently undocumented, and where the depth of engagement required for scholarly understanding is best achieved through sustained interpretive engagement with individual experience rather than through aggregative comparison. The findings are offered not as a basis for statistical generalisation but as a theoretically grounded account from which analytical insights about sound engineering formation, creative practice, and professional mentorship may be drawn in relation to other contexts.

Because the study draws mainly on Ansa-Asare's own retrospective interview accounts, the findings should be understood as an in-depth account of one practitioner's professional experience rather than a representation of all Ghanaian sound engineers. Future studies can extend this work by examining archival recordings and studio documents and by interviewing collaborators, mentees, conductors, and other engineers. Comparative studies of practitioners working in choral and popular music would also help to develop a broader account of sound engineering practice in Ghana.

More broadly, this study affirms the scholarly urgency of expanding Ghanaian and African music scholarship beyond its historical concentration on composers and performers to encompass the technical practitioners, sound engineers, producers, live sound specialists, whose decisions shape how African music sounds, how it is preserved, and how it circulates. These practitioners are bearers of irreplaceable professional knowledge, aesthetic values, and cultural experience. Their documentation is not merely a scholarly exercise; it is a contribution to the preservation of African musical heritage.

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